

Even as I was grappling with this letter, there arrived another seeking details of my trades in a mid-cap IT stock. In this case, I had dealt for a fund manager who would later buy a huge quantity for his fund. To cut a long story short, this too was an unlawful trade.

Both trades were over a year old and I had forgotten about them. But somebody at the regulator had investigated them. I could understand their smelling out the trades in the bulk drugs firm because even the media had hinted at insider trading because of the rise in share prices ahead of the deal. But the letter relating to the trades in the IT firm could only have been the result of an anonymous tip-off to the regulator. With a good lawyer I would be able to wriggle out of it. I thought about it and finally concluded that somebody powerful was targeting me. I had no clue as to who that person could be, but it had to be somebody I had unknowingly offended. I told GB about my predicament and he promised to check if my fears were justified.

He called me a couple of days later, confirming my suspicions.

‘You were right, Lala,’ he said, coming to the point directly. ‘You are in the bad books of Mr V. Apparently he has not forgiven you for going after his stock at a time when he had pledged his shares.’

Mr V was among the top twenty-five industrialists in the country, and I had heard stories of how he could be extremely charming but also extremely vindictive if he believed he had been slighted.

‘I thought he was mature enough to understand that there was nothing personal about it,’ I said.

‘That is how you see it. But your raid on his stock came at a vulnerable point in his business, and he has not forgiven you for it. In fact, he had sworn to force you out of the market, and is now doing everything he can to make good his threat,’ GB said.

‘I am not going anywhere,’ I said defiantly.

‘You don’t have to,’ GB assured me. ‘Let me see what can be done about this.’

A few days later he called again. He had nothing cheerful to say.

‘The way I see it, Lala, Mr V is now in a much sounder position than he was two years ago. He now has some powerful friends in the right places. You can dig in your heels, but there will be more show cause notices coming your way. What I am more worried about is that some of the charges will be hard to shake off. Your only defence would be to name the